

Sports **HOCKEY**



Top Guns

Teun de Nooijer
(Ned) The Dutch veteran is an exceptionally fast and skilful finisher in front of goal.

Jamie Dwyer
(Aus) Nicknamed Foetus, the Aussie captain has scored more than 120 international goals, winning Olympic gold in Athens 2004.

Pablo 'Pol' Amat Escudé
(Esp) Often called the Ronaldinho of hockey, his late goals seal games for Spain.

Matthias Witthaus
(Ger) The youngest ever goal-scorer for Germany, Witthaus' pace is hard to match.

Sohail Abbas
(Pak) A penalty corner specialist, Abbas is also one of the finest defenders in hockey today.

cently introduced an 'individual player sponsorship programme', inviting companies, clubs and individuals to support the players on its elite men's and women's team.

The Dutch, who have won three World Cups and two Olympic golds, have clubs and competitions with seven youth-age ranges from under-6 to under-18, followed by the main team/elite group as well as over-35 and over-50s. Its hockey attracts sponsors who support the highest clubs and pay their best players, several drawn from overseas. Junior scouts look for talent from the under-13s onward and an under-18 national team is buffeted by an under-18 reserve squad. The elite German squad goes into a 80-90-day camp and plays 25-35 matches a year. The Dutch national team train weekly and switch to daily training, when major events approach. These are different

launched by ESPN India. Three good years ended with the sudden but long-delayed extinction of the Indian Hockey Federation (IHF) led by KPS Gill. The IHF's rebirth is near impossible because as an industry insider puts it, "ESPN's focus has shifted to ICC events and the Champions League T20." Indian hockey is struggling with its own organisational rebirth with the newly-created Hockey India (HI) whose elections are yet to be held. Charlesworth says that India's decline was not due to, "either the artificial turf or rule changes... They (India) have failed to modernise the game."

Modern now means new routes for Indian hockey. "We don't need colossal amounts of money," says a player, "we need colossal planning and strategy." HI's former president A.K. Mattoo says administrative roles need to be identified and accepted, a rewards scheme worked

COACHING NEEDS TO BE STREAMLINED WITH COACHES AT ALL LEVELS TEACHING THE SPORTS SCIENCE OFF A COMMON, MODERN TEMPLATE.

routes with a gap in funding, but neither have been disasters like India. Our national championships have been held thrice in the last 10 years: Jammu 2000, Hyderabad 2005, Jalandhar 2006. India has no structured league or planned calendar.

Is There No Hope At All? What Must be Done?

In the sports management business, Indian hockey is a strangely smelling fruit. Sports marketing professional Anirban Das Blah, managing director, KWAN, says "I have no doubt hockey has huge potential. But the sport is spectacularly mismanaged, both organisationally and operationally. There are too many horror stories." The spate of sponsorships of the World Cup—said to be just under Rs 30 crore—are more event-driven than sport-centric. Five years ago, the Premier Hockey League (PHL) was

out and resources understood. Menezes wants accountability across the sport and for India to play regularly against the world's top four. Carvalho wants a uniform training of coaches at local level and says, "Preparation, exposure and planning, that's what leads to podium finishes."

India are not expected to have any at this World Cup but the team knows it must start well. D'Souza says, "This can be a pretty good time for us. We will be playing at home. We have to shut down whatever has happened and be mentally strong."

Even Carvalho is chuckling. "Indian hockey is not going to die. The administrators running the game... they may die." The optimists believe death is not close, yet there is no denying Indian hockey is on life support. The World Cup will show us if it can breathe on its own again. ■